Design Thinking

In this section we're going to look at the following

- The purpose and power of design thinking

How will this help me in my role?

This analysis is relevant to many roles involved in strategic analysis and business change. For example, Digital Business Leads, Product Managers, Operational Managers, Strategic Managers, Product Owners and Business Analysts.

Design Thinking

Design thinking can be used whenever solution design work is carried out. It is an iterative process, and may be used several times during an agile delivery, in this case it becomes a more intuitive part of the overall process.

Design thinking underpins the agile collaborative philosophy of being open to new ideas and flexible enough to let designs evolve. It also fits with the rituals and routines that are in place to review and act on feedback.

Design thinking can also be used on waterfall projects or as part of business-as-usual work.

Divergent and Convergent Thinking

As part of the identification of options process, it may be useful to use divergent and convergent thinking.

Divergent thinking encourages evolutionary, imaginative and diverse thinking and aims to consider a wide range of possibilities, although many may be later discarded.

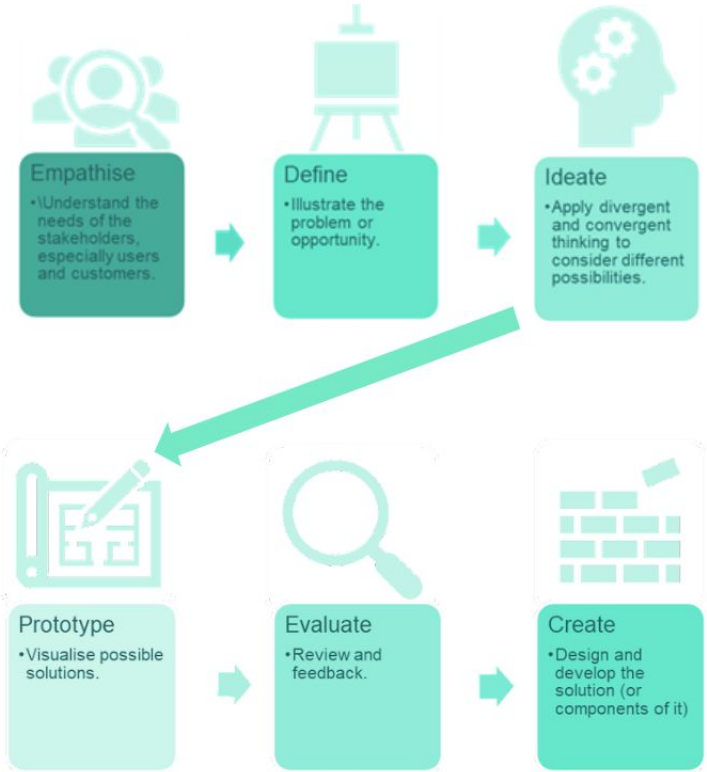
Convergent thinking is narrower in focus on addressing the problem or opportunity.

Divergent and convergent are powerful when used together and even more powerful when used as part of design thinking, which revolves around the key concepts shown in the next slide.

Design thinking supports evolutionary design and fast feedback loops. It therefore works well in an agile environment but can also be used during the initial stages of a linear lifecycle.

Six Thinking Hats

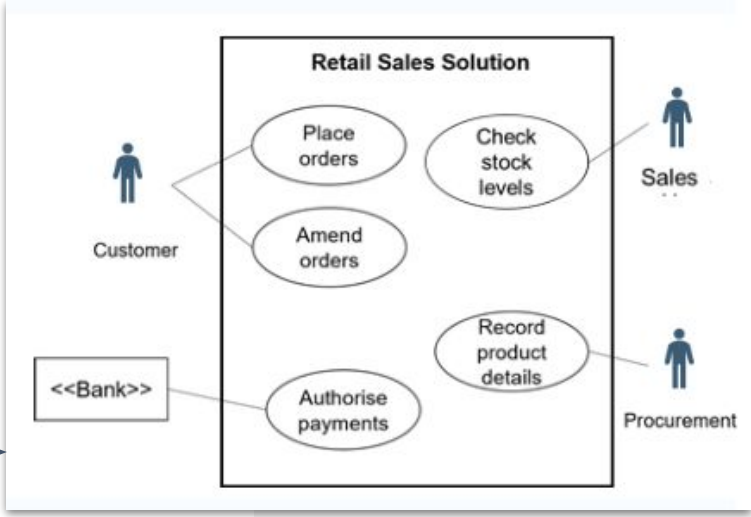
The Six Thinking Hats approach to Creative Thinking by De Bono is a useful technique, as shown in the attached video link https://youtu.be/NQNCrEHxlr0



Use Case Diagrams

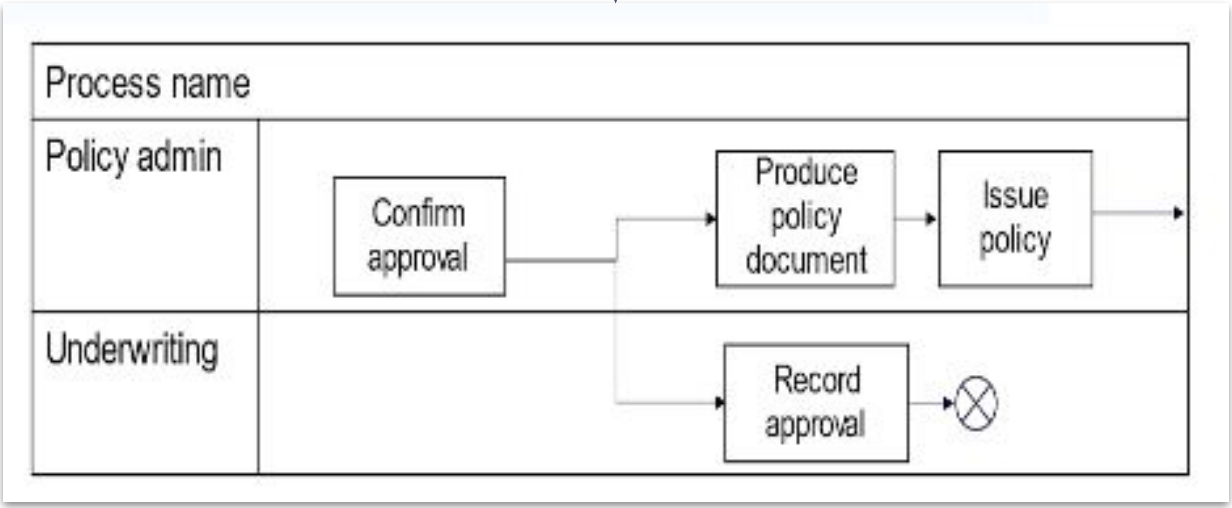
Visualisation techniques help stakeholders to understand an aspect of the system and the requirements for it. In visualising models or prototypes, stakeholders can reflect on the system from their own perspective and contribute to the requirements. Different models also help to encourage certain views:

A ***use case diagram*** helps users to visualise what the system needs to do and the interaction between actors and system functionality



Process Models

A ***process model*** helps stakeholders to visualise the to be process. They can think about exceptions and alternate paths, decisions, rules, sequence, parallel processing and anything that is missing from the new process



More Techniques

Prototypes can also be demonstrated within a workshop environment. They too help stakeholders to visualise the future system and consider usability aspects.

User stories can be used within workshops in many different ways. For example they could be elicited, discussed, elaborated, sized, prioritised.

Mind maps may be used capture a visual image of the situation and used for reflection/discussion during the workshop.

Divergent and Convergent Thinking

Discovery techniques help stakeholders to think of ideas, or requirements that have not yet been requested

Idea storming invites individuals or groups to shout out their ideas and a facilitator will capture them centrally, usually on a board or flipchart. Often the group spark ideas within each other.

Sticky notes (physical or virtual) offer a quick and easy method for stakeholders to contribute ideas without interrupting each other's creative energy. Although contribution to sticky note exercises are usually optional, there is an unwritten rule saying that each person must write at least one or two notes. Thus, discreetly encouraging participation

Divergent and Convergent Thinking

Brainwriting is usually conducted within breakout groups and involves writing ideas related to a given topic on a sheet of paper and passing it round for others to contribute. If there were say 6 people in a group, 6 sheets could be passed around at the same time. The idea being that the group can build on each other's ideas without interrupting each other.

Breakout groups are useful in workshops, because people may be more confident in smaller groups. Different groups could discuss the same topics and the results could be compared and merged, or different topics could be covered and others could be invited to add their thoughts when each group plays back their thoughts. The former is likely to be more thorough and the latter more efficient.

Divergent and Convergent Thinking

Round robins involve the facilitator asking each participant in turn to give their view, or a piece of information. On the plus side, they ensure that everyone participates, on the negative side, they put participants on the spot and may cause them discomfort.